

Localisation

Localise Application

Help Files

This article focuses on the nuances of localising application help files.

Online help and User manuals are given lesser priority when localising software. This is usually due to complexity of the help/documentation and also inadequate understanding of dealing with the relevant files. Most help documentation consists of multiple pages written in some form of markup language with each page consisting of paragraphs and links to other pages. XML based mark-up languages have traditionally been used for help documentation. There are helpful utilities to generate documentation in HTML, PDF and other online formats.

In this article, I present the structure of the help files, explore Mallard project for online help and illustrate the sequence of steps for localising with Gedit as an example.

The structure of help files

On a typical UNIX system, help files are stored as follows:

```
/usr/share/help
|--/gedit : Application
|----/C :Reference help in English-US
|----/te : Language help inTelugu
|----/hi : Language help in Hindi
```

Under each help directory, there is a set of mark-up files and a directory for figures. Each mark-up file can be converted into a '.po' file, which can be translated in a localisation environment and converted back to XML. XML utilities are used for these steps. As there can be several XML files, there are also tools available to convert all of them into a single '.po' file, which can be converted back to XML files after translation.

After translation, the XML files and figures are copied into the designated location, so that the system's help engine can pick them up as per the locale of the user. For error checking, the translated files can be viewed in the help browser, or can be processed to yield HTML or PDF files.

Mallard

Mallard is gaining momentum as a mark-up language better suited for the purposes of online help. Its chief advantage is reference inversion, i.e., each page specifies the names of other pages that are to be linked to it. The Mallard compiler ensures

that help pages are updated with proper links from the source pages. This makes the documentation evolve with the software, with changes required to fewer files. A lot of disadvantages of the older Docbook format have also been overcome with Mallard.

Process for gedit localisation

Let's look at how to localise the Gedit help into Telugu. Gedit is a popular and powerful editor in GNOME environment. It supports internationalized text (UTF-8) and features configurable syntax highlighting for various languages along with print preview, configurable fonts. Figure 1 shows the Telugu version of Gedit (localised) and Figure 2 shows its help page (in English). Install *itstool* (on Ubuntu, `sudo apt-get install itstool`). If any of the commands in the following steps don't work, install the corresponding packages and repeat the steps.

Step1: Locate the reference Gedit documentation on your system as per the details given earlier, or clone the repository with `git clone http://git.gnome.org/browse/gedit`.

Step 2: Build *te.po* from the reference help files. The following commands are for the local version of the Gedit documentation repository, if the Telugu PO file is not already part of the package: "at /usr/share/help/te".



Note: I picked the Gedit application as an example for this, as it is the default text editor of GNOME. I have tried out everything mentioned in this article on Ubuntu 12.04 and configured it for Telugu. You may need to adapt the steps for your OS and locale.

```
$ cd gedit/help/C
$ itstool -l te *.page -o ../te/te.po
```

Step 3: Translate the PO file. Use Poedit or any PO file editor or the Gedit text editor itself to translate. Make use of the translation memories and glossaries available for your language to enhance productivity and consistency. Keep Gedit open in the desired locale, and take care to use the localised UI in the help documentation. One easy way to ensure this is to generate translation memory and glossary from the localised UI po file, and to use localisation tool such as poedit to provide translation tips. As the strings may